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UNIZIK FRESHER EDITION | 2026

THA 152: Introduction to Media Arts - Radio, Television and Film Basics

How a media production is actually put together

THEATRE & FILM

Theatre & Film Studies

Faculty of Arts
Theatre & Film Studies | 100L

OUTLINE ARCHIVE: 2018 - 2019 - 2025/2026

Written for students, by students.

Practical notes, worked examples, practice questions and a revision plan.

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Independent study support | Not an official UNIZIK publication

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Why this pack exists

This pack explains the production chain for radio, television and film, the roles in a production team, and the basic grammar of shot sizes and sound. It is the foundation for THA 215, THA 252 and THA 324, so treat it as a map rather than a list of definitions.

This is a student-written study companion, not a reproduced lecture handout or a leaked examination paper. Use it to organise the topics you are taught, practise the kind of thinking your course rewards, and walk into class with better questions.

What you will be able to do

- Describe pre-production, production and post-production stages.
- Identify the roles in a media production team and what each owns.
- Use shot sizes, camera angles and transitions accurately.
- Explain how radio differs from television and film in production logic.

How to use this pack

1. Skim the whole pack once in 20 minutes so you know what is inside.
2. Work through one section at a time with your lecture note and recommended text beside you.
3. Attempt the practice questions before reading the answers. Mark what you missed.
4. Use the final checklist to plan your revision week, one tick per study session.

> **Free to download, always**
> This pack is free. There is no fee, no subscription and no payment step before download, and the full PDF is not watermarked or locked. Share the link with a coursemate instead of forwarding the file.

> **Confirm your official course outline**
> Course codes, credit units and outlines can differ by department and session. Treat this pack as supplementary support and confirm the current outline with your lecturer, course rep or departmental handbook before an assessment.

The production chain

Every production, from a radio jingle to a feature film, moves through three phases.

- Pre-production: idea, script, budget, schedule, crew, location and permissions.
- Production: shooting or recording, with continuity and safety management.
- Post-production: editing, sound, colour, graphics and delivery.
- Radio compresses the chain: script, record, edit, broadcast.
- Failures in pre-production surface as chaos on set.
- Keep a paper trail: scripts, schedules, release forms and logs.

Roles and responsibilities

Credit correctly and know who decides what.

- Producer: money, logistics and overall delivery.
- Director: interpretation and creative decisions.
- Scriptwriter: structure and dialogue.
- Cinematographer or camera operator: image and lighting.
- Sound recordist and designer: dialogue, effects and mix.
- Editor: rhythm, continuity and final structure.

> **Say what you own**
> In group projects, write down who owns which deliverable. Ambiguity is the main cause of 'I did everything' disputes.

Visual grammar and sound

Learn the vocabulary before you analyse a film.

- Shot sizes: extreme wide, wide, medium, close-up, extreme close-up.
- Angles: eye level, high, low, Dutch tilt.
- Movement: pan, tilt, dolly, handheld, crane.
- Transitions: cut, dissolve, fade, wipe.
- Sound: diegetic (inside the story world) and non-diegetic (score, narration).
- Continuity: eyeline, screen direction and the 180-degree rule.

Three media, three production logics

Radio, television and film share equipment and vocabulary but organise production differently. Radio has no image, so it must build place, character and action through voice, effects and silence; a listener cannot re-read a sentence, which is why radio writing repeats key information and keeps sentences short.

Television is usually produced against time and in formats: a package with a presenter link, an interview with cutaways, a magazine segment with a fixed duration. The grammar is continuity-based, and the constraint is that the audience may join at any moment, so context must be re-established regularly.

Film is the most controllable and the most expensive per minute. Coverage is shot out of order, so continuity and logging matter more than in the other two, and the story is finally built in the edit. Understanding which logic you are working in prevents the common student error of shooting a film as if it were a recorded stage play.

Grammar you must be able to name

Shot size is a relationship, not a measurement: an extreme wide establishes geography, a wide shows the body in space, a medium frames gesture, a close-up carries internal state, and an extreme close-up isolates detail. Angles carry attitude - a low angle enlarges the subject, a high angle reduces it, a Dutch tilt destabilises.

Continuity depends on three rules that students break most often. The 180-degree rule keeps camera positions on one side of an imaginary line between two subjects so screen direction stays consistent. The 30-degree rule requires a new shot to change angle by at least 30 degrees, otherwise it reads as a jump. Eyeline match keeps a character looking in a consistent direction across cuts.

Sound is not an afterthought: diegetic sound exists in the story world, non-diegetic sound is added for the audience, and a sound bridge links scenes. Room tone recorded on location is what makes an edit sound continuous; without it, cuts produce audible holes.

> **Log before you shoot**
> A shot log - scene, shot, take, notes - costs two minutes on set and saves hours in the edit. Without it you will review footage by guessing.

OUTLINE ARCHIVE

Session record: THA 152

2018 - 2019 - 2025/2026

Year demarcation matters: a course code that existed in 2018 may have been renumbered, merged or dropped by 2019, and the department now also runs a film track. Read the year label before you rely on a code. The current entry below is a compiled map - take it to your course rep or the departmental office and confirm it before registration.

2018 — Archived course description — ARCHIVED

- THA 152 Introduction to Media Arts sits inside the 100-level media area
- The 2018 description frames media study through production participation and studio practice
- THA 252 Fundamentals of Radio, Television and Film Production is described on the same page

Source: unizik.edu.ng - Theatre & Film Studies course description (page dated 31 May 2018; original URL now returns 404) (retrieved 2026-10-22)

2019 — Archived programme listing — ARCHIVED

- THA 152 Introduction to Media Arts, 3 credits, second semester
- Media stress area continues with THA 215, 252, 324 and 333
- The department describes radio, TV and film as broadcast arts within theatre studies

What changed: The 2019 listing shows a clearer media ladder: 152 introduces, 215 analyses film, 252 introduces production, 324 directs.

Source: arts.unizik.edu.ng - Theatre Arts programme and course map (page dated 18 Oct 2019; original URL now returns 404) (retrieved 2026-10-22)

2025/2026 — Compiled working map — CURRENT WORKING MAP

- Media arts remains the 100-level gateway to the film and broadcast track
- The department now includes Film Studies in its name, so expect stronger film emphasis
- Confirm which editing software and equipment your cohort can access

Source: Compiled by ZikShare from the archived 2018 and 2019 departmental pages plus the published stress areas; this is a working map, not an official handout (retrieved 2026-10-22)

Archive means: this records what a public departmental page listed in that year. It is not a guarantee of the current curriculum, and ZikShare is not affiliated with UNIZIK.

WORKED EXAMPLES

Do it once, slowly

These are not model answers to copy. They show the reasoning a strong student would use, step by step, so you can repeat the process on a question you have not seen.

1. Planning coverage for a two-person scene

You have one camera, one hour and a two-page dialogue scene. Here is the coverage plan.

1. Shoot a wide master of the whole scene first; it protects the edit and establishes geography.
2. Shoot over-the-shoulder singles for each character, keeping the camera on the same side of the line.
3. Add a clean close-up of the moment the scene turns - the reaction that carries the meaning.
4. Collect cutaways: hands, a prop, a doorway, and 30 seconds of room tone.
5. Log every take as you shoot, noting the best one and why.
6. In the edit, build the scene from the master, then cut to singles on the beats, then cover the joins with cutaways.

> **What to carry forward**
> Coverage is insurance. The master protects you when a performance peaks in a take you did not expect.

2. Diagnosing a bad cut

Your edited scene feels jumpy and the two characters seem to look at each other from the same side. What went wrong?

1. Check the line: if the camera crossed the 180-degree line, screen direction reverses and the audience loses geography.
2. Check the angle change: two shots from nearly the same position produce a visible jump.
3. Check eyelines: each actor must look at a consistent point off camera.
4. Check sound: an abrupt room-tone change makes the cut audible.
5. Fix by inserting a neutral shot, re-blocking, or re-shooting one side rather than by adding effects.

> **What to carry forward**
> Most "bad editing" is a shooting error. Fix the cause, not the symptom.

EXAM TECHNIQUE

Questions with model answers

Written in the shape your course is usually examined, with the marking logic spelled out. Attempt each one under time before you read the outline.

Q1. Explain the 180-degree rule and the effect of breaking it.

10 marks

1. Define the imaginary line between two subjects.
2. State the rule: keep all camera positions on one side of it.
3. Explain the effect of breaking it: screen direction reverses and the audience loses spatial orientation.
4. Give the standard fixes: cutaway, neutral shot, or re-establishing wide.

Q2. Compare the production logic of radio with that of film.

15 marks

1. Radio: sound-only, linear, listener cannot re-read, small crew, fast turnaround.
2. Film: visual and aural, shot out of order, expensive per minute, story built in the edit.
3. Show how each logic changes writing: radio repeats and simplifies; film can rely on image and subtext.
4. Show how each changes production: radio compresses the chain; film demands coverage and continuity.
5. Conclude that the medium determines the workflow, not only the style.

> **Where marks are lost**
> Describing radio as "film without pictures". The constraints are different, not reduced.

REFERENCE

Glossary

Use these definitions in your own sentences; a copied definition rarely earns full marks.

Shot size. The framing of a subject, from extreme wide to extreme close-up, used to guide attention.

180-degree rule. The convention of keeping all camera positions on one side of an imaginary line so screen direction stays consistent.

30-degree rule. The requirement that a new shot of the same subject change angle by at least 30 degrees to avoid a jump cut.

Eyeline match. Cutting between shots so that a character's gaze remains consistent in direction.

Diegetic sound. Sound that exists within the story world and can be heard by the characters.

Non-diegetic sound. Sound added for the audience, such as a score or narration, that characters do not hear.

Room tone. The ambient sound of a location recorded separately to smooth edits.

Coverage. The range of shots captured for a scene so that it can be edited.

Master shot. A wide shot capturing the whole scene, used as the structural backbone of the edit.

Sound bridge. Audio that continues across a cut, linking two scenes.

Pre-production. The planning phase: script, budget, schedule, crew, locations and permissions.

Rough cut. A first assembly of the footage that establishes structure before refinement.

Your four-week plan

Week 1 - Grammar

Name what you see.

- Log every shot in a two-minute scene.
- Identify five shot sizes and three angles.
- Mark one continuity error and explain it.

Week 2 - Plan

Pre-production.

- Write a one-page production plan.
- Draw a simple floor plan and camera positions.
- List permissions and equipment you need.

Week 3 - Shoot

Coverage and sound.

- Shoot a master plus singles for one scene.
- Record room tone and cutaways.
- Keep a shot log for every take.

Week 4 - Edit

Assembly to rough cut.

- Build the scene from the master.
- Cut on beats, cover the joins.
- Screen it for two people and note where attention dropped.

Where to read more

Entry-level texts you can find in the university library or a departmental reading list. Confirm editions with your lecturer.

- Any introductory film studies text on shot grammar, continuity and sound.
- A radio production handbook section on writing for the ear.
- Your department's equipment booking and safety rules before your first shoot.

PRACTICE, NOT PREDICTION

Check your understanding

These questions are written for this pack to test the ideas above. They are not past examination questions and do not predict what your lecturer will set. Answer first, then compare.

1. What are the three production phases?

Answer: Pre-production, production and post-production.

2. What is the difference between diegetic and non-diegetic sound?

Answer: Diegetic sound exists in the story world and can be heard by characters; non-diegetic sound, such as a score, is added for the audience.

3. Who is responsible for continuity on set?

Answer: The continuity supervisor or script supervisor, working with the director and editor.

4. Give one reason radio production differs from film production.

Answer: Radio has no visual channel, so it must build place, character and action through voice, sound effects and silence.

5. What is the 180-degree rule?

Answer: Keeping the camera on one side of an imaginary line between two characters preserves consistent screen direction.

Your 7-step action plan

Tick each step only when you have done it. A tick you cannot defend is worse than an empty box.

- [ ] Write the three production phases with tasks for each.
- [ ] Draw a production team chart with ten roles.
- [ ] Learn ten shot types with a sketch of each.
- [ ] Analyse a three-minute scene for shot sizes and sound.
- [ ] Make a one-page radio production plan.
- [ ] Watch a behind-the-scenes documentary and list three logistics lessons.
- [ ] Define diegetic and non-diegetic sound using a scene you know.

Keep going

One pack will not carry a semester. Pair this with your lecture notes, tutorials, and the past questions your department actually releases. If a topic still feels unclear, take a specific question to your lecturer or course rep - "I do not understand the difference between X and Y" gets a better answer than "I do not understand this course".

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YOUR WORKSPACE

Notes, questions and things to ask

Use this page in class or during revision. Write questions you could not answer instead of copying slides.

Three ideas I can now explain without notes:

A question I still cannot answer:

For my lecturer or course rep:

Next revision action and date:

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